After All These Years: Part I

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/28464093.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), George (She-Ra), Lance (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Fluff, Domestic Fluff, there's a little bowfuma and scorfuma but not engough to like tag, high school sweethearts to college sweethearts to a life long love story

Language:
English

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Part 1 of The Book of Love: After All These Years—A Love Story

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After All These Years: Part I

by watertribesato

Summary

Sometimes you meet someone and are able to find a unique comfort in their presence. Sometimes it's friendship, sometimes love and if you're really lucky: it might be both. Adora and Glimmer were both really lucky.

Playlist: after all these years, a playlist for a fic: parts i-iv

Songs Specific to Part I:
It's Nice to Have a Friend - Taylor Swift
Friends Don't - Maddie & Tae
Just Friends - Jonas Brothers
Young and In Love - Ingrid Michaelson

Notes

This one's a doozy. So this entire fic started as peeks of Adora and Glimmer's relationship through the senses (touch, taste, smell, etc etc) but then it turned into so much more and now this is one of my favorite things I have created. This is always been what i consider a love letter not only to Glimmadora but also to my friends. That being said, specifically, this is a gift and love letter to my four pals: Ash, Meg, Rod, & Osprey. I don't know how I would have survived this hell year with these guys and I love them so much.

This is gonna be broken down into 4 parts, each with their own little stories of Adora and Glimmer. It is complete and I'll be updating until all the parts are completed! It's all mainly fluff because like I said this is all my Glimmadora fans and with the year that 2020 was and everything, who wants more angst in their lives!!

And surprise! Would it be me if I didn't have a playlist? I'll link a playlist I made that soundtracks this entire work and I'll let you know exactly which songs match up.

I hope anyone who reads this will enjoy it!

Here's the link to the playlist: after all these years, a playlist for a fic: parts i-iv

See the end of the work for more notes

'mara'

Adora watched as the ball came down for what had to be the thousandth time since the trio of best friends began to brainstorm for their project. Fiddling with an object always seemed to help her concentrate—something about the rhythm of the ups and downs seemed to streamline and focus her thoughts.

She felt the bed shift under her back as Glimmer stretched out her body and groaned loudly from frustration. Glimmer's leg was casually placed over her own. The weight of Glimmer's leg on her own occasionally broke her concentration. The two always seemed to be in constant touch—whether it be the casual touches in between classes, their legs brushing at lunch, or when they sat side to side doing homework in Glimmer's room most afternoons. The blonde didn't mind, she looked forward to their brief moments of contact.

"We've been at this for two hours already.." Glimmer spoked muffled as she pushed her face into the mattress, "It's not even due for another week!"

"Yeah, but Adora and I have our tournament coming up so we should do this before that, right Adora?" Bow said looking up from his laptop. He sat opposite the bed at Glimmer's desk.

"Don't drag Adora into this, you just want to make me do work because you hate me"

"You caught me Glimmer! I hate you" Bow feigned shock, "And I've spent the past ten years becoming your best friend to trick into doing our Lit project"

Adora caught the ball and held it on her chest loudly laughing at Bow's quip. Glimmer turned her face and poked a finger softly into Adora's cheek:

“Don’t encourage him,” Glimmer’s face was still half pressed into the mattress.

“I mean, he’s kinda funny” Adora teased back causing Glimmer to roll her only visible eye,

“Who knew trying to come up with a kid’s story would be so hard,” Glimmer continued

“It’s not hard, everyone else just took the really good ones,” Bow answered, taking his glasses off to rub his face, his eyes straining from staring at the computer for too long.

“What about *‘A Rainbow of My Own’* ? I used to read it to Frosta when I babysat her” Glimmer suggested, perking up slightly.

“Can’t, Perfuma already called dibs” Bow sighed.

“Ow!” Adora quietly spoke out as the ball bounced onto her head. Glimmer’s suggestion unearthing a specific memory.

“You okay ‘Dora?” Glimmer asked, concerned, scrawled over her tone.

“Yeah...I just thought of—have you guys ever heard of the Rainbow Crow?” Adora spoke her voice trailing as if still searching for the answer to her own question.

“I don’t think so?” Bow looked up from his laptop staring at the two girls laying next to each other. Glimmer propped her head on her hand before she started to speak:

“Rainbow Crow? What’s that one about?” Glimmer said, her voice drawing Adora’s eyes to her. Adora flipped herself over onto her stomach and she brought both her hands up to her face in a clasped fist while her eyebrows scrunched, her mind still stitching the story piece by piece deep within her memory.

“I don’t fully remember the whole story but,” she started slowly careful with her words, “The world was getting covered in a snow

and the animals wanted to send a messenger to the Creator to ask them to stop the snow" Adora paused again before she continued: "They couldn't agree who to send to the Creator until the Rainbow Crow volunteered to go."

"The crow goes on a journey to the Creator—and oh!" Adora abruptly interrupted her own sentence startling Bow causing a small giggle to escape Glimmer, "Sorry, I forgot to mention the crow has a beautiful voice that's important but yeah he goes and gets the Creator's attention by singing. The Creator gives him the gift of fire to be able to stop the snow and help his friends and uhhh"

"What happens next?" Glimmer's voice danced around Adora's recollection stammering her speech for a few months. Adora lets out a small breathy chuckle and shakes her head before she can speak again:

"Um, oh! On his way back the fire burns and darkens his feathers and the smoke causes his voice to get really hoarse. I think some other stuff happens but he gets back and his friends are safe and happy but he's sad because he lost his feathers and his voice"

A chorus of sympathetic aw's filled the room and Adora giggled at her friends' investment into her story,

"Guys, it has a happy ending I promise"

"It better, I'm really invested in this crow" Bow spoke up crossing his arms with a deep frown to which both girls laughed,

"If I remember exactly, the Creator sees the crow being really sad and reassures him that he still has value and because he was unselfish and brave eventually when people come his gift will be freedom because he doesn't have anything people will desire. And that even in his now black feathers there's still rainbows if you look closely"

"That's so cute. I think I might cry" Glimmer said, "We should totally do that one, what do you think Bow?"

“I’m already making the presentation!” Bow shot back as he furiously typed away

“Sorry, if I told it wrong or bad” Adora sat up, crossing her legs on the bed. She rubbed her neck slightly, now anxious that her retelling wasn’t up to par.

“What are you talking about? You told it beautifully...you almost made Bow cry” Glimmer teased as she placed a gentle hand on Adora’s knee.

“It was an emotional journey okay?” Bow shot back, defending himself.

“Where’d you hear it?” Glimmer asked as she lifted her hand off of her knee causing a small pang of disappointment to ring inside Adora.

“Um,” Adora thought for a moment, struggling to place exactly where it came from. After a few moments, the puzzle pieces in her mind shifted together and created a solidified image causing a flood of sadness to engulf her, she let out a small exhale:

“My mo—” she caught herself, ”Foster mom would always tell it to me as a bedtime story,” Bow’s head shot up almost immediately and spoke in pure disbelief.

“Sharon!?” he questioned. Glimmer let out a incredulous chuckle:

“No offense but she doesn’t like the type to read bedtime stories?”

“Oh god no, no” Adora shook her head, “I had another foster mom before her when I was little. Yeah, her name was—,” Adora’s hesitated her mouth straining to form the word it hadn’t it years, “Mara”

The room was silent, Adora lost in her thought and her friends both sensing the mere mention of the name came with an unearthed story prior to Adora being present in their lives. Neither

really sure what to say next if anything at all. After a moment and a few quick glances with Bow, Glimmer spoke.

“That’s a beautiful name...what..what was she like?”

Adora broke from her trance and looked to her friend who held a small smile and returned it before she answered:

“She was nice..yeah she was really nice”

“Why didn’t you stay with her?” Glimmer carefully asked but the question still caught Adora off guard and she spluttered her words momentarily.

“Uh—Uh..I...I don’t know?”

“What do you mean you don’t know?” Glimmer continued to press as Bow called out her name softly,

“Glimmer…”

“I don’t know...I was a kid..” Adora snapped back quickly

“You didn’t ask, you didn’t wonder—”

“Glimmer.” Bow spoke again interrupting Glimmer, this time his voice louder.

“It’s not like I got a choice!” Adora’s voice filled the room, the pain behind her words sucking the oxygen out. Glimmer was taken back her mouth slightly agape, immediate regret spread all over her face. Bow’s voice cut through the tense atmosphere.

“Let’s..uh let’s just focus on the project?” He glanced at the clock, “It’s getting late and we should probably start wrapping up” Both girls nodded solemnly, neither knew exactly how to fix it.

The rest of the night the trio navigated eggshells, both Glimmer and Adora uncharacteristically quiet and overly polite with each other and Bow doing his best to maneuver it all.

Eventually, the night came to a quiet end. Adora and Bow said their goodbyes to Angella who was stationed in the living room, still working.

After a quick hug between Glimmer and Bow, Adora noticed Glimmer hesitate and hover near her. Not sure if she should reach out. The blonde stepped closer slightly bridging the gap between them, hoping her signal would come across. Glimmer cautiously stepped forward and Adora pulled her into an embrace, the hug was tight and the two bodies lingered together.

“Let me know when you get home?” Glimmer’s voice was muffled into Adora’s shoulder

“Of course,” Adora’s voice was soft as they parted.

“What, you don’t care if I make it home. Wow, you think you know someone..” Bow scoffed as Glimmer gingerly punched his arm.

“Shut up, you live like three houses down” the trio laughed wholeheartedly again for the first time since the air of awkwardness surrounded them, each of them seemingly letting out a sigh of relief amongst each other.

Adora and Bow strolled over to Bow’s home, their conversation was light, joking about their upcoming soccer tournament. Adora was eagerly greeted by Bow’s fathers once they reached his home as well as Bow’s older twin brothers, both visiting from school. George and Lance both took an immediate liking to Adora at the first introduction, often joking about Adora being their long-awaited daughter.

“You sure we can’t give you a ride?” Lance clasped tightly to her hands with the biggest puppy eyes that Adora was sure Bow inherited. She let out a big laugh,

“I wouldn’t want to inconvenience you,” she caught a slight frown touch Lance’s lips, “And it’s such a nice night out, I’m kinda

looking forward to it,"

"Adora, you're never an inconvenience, ever. But it is a nice night." George placed a gentle hand on his husband's shoulder and continued, "Be careful and let us know when you get home, okay?"

Adora picked up her bike from the ground and threw a leg over the seat positioning herself to leave their home. Her face held a wide smile as she turned back to say her goodbyes.

"You know it!" She pushed off her bike and began to pedal fully aware George and Lance would be watching her until she rounded the corner out of the neighborhood, as they often did.

As she rounded the corner, the smile fell off of her lips as quickly as she had plastered it on. Adora's hand's gripped the handles of her bike tight, her knuckles a ghostly white. She expertly rode her bikes through the neighborhoods in between Glimmer and Bow's to her own. Usually, a quick and furious speed would bring her to her house in no time flat but her wandering mind forced her pace to slow.

The night was cool and felt refreshing on her skin, burning hot trying to push back the flood of incoming emotion. She hadn't thought about Mara in so long, they weren't painful memories and somehow that always made it worse.

Adora didn't always remember her childhood well, most of it generally categorized as before Sharon and well, *Sharon* . But she always remembered her time with Mara; most particularly the last night she spent at a home where she, for the first and the last time prior to meeting her Glimmer and Bow, felt truly at home.

Adora remembered they were making the next day's lunch, Mara was showing her how to julienne vegetables. She was practicing saying the new word her foster mom had taught her.

"Juliet? Like at school?" Adora had beamed at Mara who started to giggle at her misunderstanding.

"Close sweetie, but no; it's 'julienne' it means to make them into tinnny strips like this," Mara had corrected, passing her a chopped carrot to chew on as she continued to practice saying the new word. A knock on the door interrupted their time together. Mara told Adora to stay in the kitchen but her curiosity of the stranger coming to their home this late got the better of her.

She pressed her small ear to the door that separated the kitchen from the living room, her ears catching the middle of a conversation that she could feel wasn't meant for her.

"Ms. Hope, I need you to understand," a rough voice pleaded— Adora, didn't recognize this voice.

"No, I don't understand, she's happy here, she's safe here," a soft voice that often read her bedtime stories retorted back, harsher than Adora had ever heard it sound.

"This was always a temporary placement Ms. Hope, but we've found her a loving home we can assure you,"

"She has a loving home, with me, right here. You can't just yank her out when you feel like it!"

"I'm sorry, Ms. Hope but if you truly do love her you'll understand and make this transition as easy as possible," Adora heard the front door open and the rough voice continued, *"We'll be by tomorrow afternoon, please make sure all her things are in order"*

Adora almost fell through the door as Mara pulled it open, the tall muscular woman catching her right before she collided with the floor.

"Honey, you have to be careful. Are you hurt?" Mara bent down meeting Adora's eyes and looked her over for injuries.

Adora shook her head and looked at her foster mother, whose eyes were completely glassy. Worry and anxiety washed over her instantly,

"Why are you sad Mara," her voice filled with distress,

Adora felt Mara grab her face and held them in her hands for a moment before she placed a gentle kiss onto her forehead.

"My sweet girl...come on, let's get you ready for bed" Mara smiled at her, her voice faltering slightly. She picked up Adora into her arms and Adora threw her arms around Mara's neck. Her anxieties instantly melted away, there was no place in the world she felt safer than in those arms.

That night Mara gave her an extra cookie before her bath and Adora thought she had won the lottery. Mara let her take a long bubble bath with all her toys which usually happened on Friday nights when she didn't have to go to school the next day. She remembered how Mara sat on the floor next to the tub the whole time, watching her play and listening to the elaborate story she had come up with for that night.

When she got to a sad part in her make-believe story, Mara started crying and Adora jumped up covered in nothing but suds eager to tell Mara, unaware the real reason for her tears:

"No, don't cry! She'll come back! She's too powerful and she loves her friends so she won't give up"

That made Mara laugh and Adora could still some days feel the happiness she felt at that moment making her laugh.

That night she got to sleep in Mara's bed with her but before she went to sleep Mara sat in her lap while her favorite show played softly in the background. Mara brushed through her hair, endlessly interrupting her focus on her show with tiny little kisses on the top of her head.

She recalled how late it was that night and how she was growing tired, the kind of tired your body felt after a long day of doing all your favorite things. She cozied further into Mara and who held her tight. Adora could feel little water droplets on her skin

occasionally but was too tired to connect that the woman holding her was crying.

"You wanna hear the story of the Rainbow Crow again baby girl?" Mara spoke quietly into her ear.

Adora hummed as she heard Mara start her favorite story, one that Mara had told her almost every night since she'd been with her. A story about a beautiful rainbow crow that gave up his feathers to bring warmth to his friends.

The next day was a bit and pieces.

She remembered a slight dread following her that day at school.

She remembered Mara picking her up and the car ride being the same: Mara asking her about her day and listening to her story.

She remembered stopping for ice cream.

She remembered coming home and seeing a social worker outside their door and Mara telling her to stay in the car.

She remembered being pulled out of the car and a random woman telling her it would be okay but knew her in gut, she was lying.

She remembered not being allowed to take her toys and hearing Mara plead with tears streaming down her face, *"Please let me say goodbye,"*

She remembered running into Mara's arms once the realization hit her.

She remembered clinging to Mara, grasping, trying to hold on. Mara held her so tight she couldn't move and she didn't care because she didn't want to let go.

She remembered being ripped away from her and placed in a car and taken to a foreign place. A place that was supposed to be

‘home,’ but was nothing but hell. A place where she would spend the next thirteen years of her life counting down the days until she could leave.

She remembered how the first time she ever screamed for her mom, was also the last time she ever saw the only woman who ever was.

Most importantly, she remembered Mara’s last words to her, whispered through sobs as they held onto each other for the last time,

“Don’t you ever forget how I love you, we will meet again my little Rainbow Crow”

The warm tears slowly slipping onto Adora’s cheek pulled her out of her memory and she found herself awkwardly standing in front of her house. Unaware of her bike ride home but thankful she didn’t hurt herself on the way. She wiped her tears with her sleeve and pulled the bike into the side of the house.

She walked quietly into the house not sure if Sharon was up or not but not looking to wake her up. The television blasted one of Sharon’s trashy reality shows as the older woman laid on the couch presumingly passed out. The light of the television illuminated her path carefully up the stairs. She reached her room and softly closed the door leaning against the door, letting out a relieved breath.

She dragged her hands up and down her face as she kicked off her shoes and flung herself into the bed. She held her hands clasped together over her forehead burning a hole into the ceiling. She let her mind wander; touching every corner briefly. Sudden memories of Mara flooded back, stitching a loose warm blanket of memories. She shook her head trying to shake out the thoughts of longing for a home she once knew, that was the past and this was now.

Adora forced herself to focus on the present and the future and almost instantly, she thought of Glimmer.

“Shit—” She patted her pocket looking for her phone, she had forgotten to let her friend know she had made it home. She brought the phone up to her face and as the screen lit up she saw two messages already waiting for her. A smile crept on her face as she began to message back:

A: Yeah, made it alright. What? Are you worried about me?

Adora began to place her phone down before she felt several vibrations in her palm. She sat up in the middle of the bed and a chuckle filled the room. The messages came in quick succession:

G: duh
G: adora?

G: I’m really sorry

A: Sorry?

G: i’m sorry if I pushed you about your old foster mom it wasn't my place and I should have realized

A: Thanks Glim, it’s alright.

A: I just hadn’t thought about it for a while so yeah

A few seconds of dots appearing and disappearing on the screen fueled Adora’s unexpected anxiety.

G: if you ever want to talk about it? I’ll be here

A: Thanks Glimmer

Adora thought for a moment.

A: What are you up to right now?

G: nothing much, sending Bow cursed images

A few seconds pass as the dots disappear once again and then a photo shoots up on the screen. Glimmer's hair was pulled into a small ponytail and pushed out of her face by a headband. Her fingers were in a peace sign next to her face, a classic Glimmer pose. She was winking and Adora could only see one of those beautiful lavender eyes. A warm sensation filled Adora's stomach, a recurring feeling that she hadn't quite realized yet.

She brings her fingers to her screen once more hesitant to send her next message but she finds the courage and sends:

A: Can I call you?

The message was marked read almost immediately and not a moment after before her phone began to ring. The picture of the two girls embracing, Glimmer insisted be her contact picture, filled the entire screen. Adora grabbed an extra pillow next to her and placed it on her chest, squeezing it close to her body. She answered the call and brought the phone to her face; there was a silence before Glimmer's voice softly rang through the phone:

"Hey you," Adora could hear the patent Glimmer smirk through the phone, even through this distance just the thought of it made her heartbeat quicken. A wider smile spread across her lips before she answered:

"Hey you too,"

They didn't intend to spend long on the phone but when conversation came so easily for the two, it was hard for Adora to keep track of the time. She didn't even remember when the phone call turned into a video chat but it had. And now it was almost four in the morning and Adora casually watched as her best friend slept on the other side of the call.

Glimmer had fallen asleep mid sentence and quite frankly Adora couldn't for the life of her remember what the pink haired girl was talking about, she just liked hearing her talk. This wasn't the first video chat turned virtual sleepover. Adora wished she was really next to Glimmer, watching the rises and falls of Glimmer's breath as she laid next to her.

She thought about their conversation, remarking on how cathartic it felt to be able to share Mara with someone else. Usually, these late night conversations took on a lighter tone but tonight they opened up to each other in a way Adora had yet to open to someone before and she felt lighter.

She replayed Glimmer's words in her mind. They gently ran over the scars of her past, caressing them with a soft touch she's never felt. Adora knew Glimmer couldn't heal them, they'd long ago scarred deep inside but her words helped Adora appreciate them for what they were. They were a part of her, a part of her story.

In a perfect world, they wouldn't exist, but this isn't a perfect world and Adora was beginning to make peace with it. Every imperfection in her world led her to her friends and *family.* It led to the sleeping girl next to her, the girl she craved to reach out and hold. The tender feeling found it's way back to the forefront of her mind and warmed her stomach yet again and an understanding showered Adora.

" *Oh,* that's what it is " Adora thought to herself as she buried her face further into her pillow, cheeks burning bright red.

'you've been stressed out lately, yeah, me too'

Glimmer hated Etheria History, well more so she hated having to sit still in class while Professor Gen droned on about this war, that treaty, this general and that other war. Gen's voice certainly was used as a torture device in every war, Glimmer thought to herself. The only solace she had, was that this was the only class she sat just far enough behind Adora that she could zone out staring at the blonde, and Adora or Bow wouldn't notice.

Today was no different, Glimmer tuned out today's lesson, *The Great Etherian War or something* , she'd con the notes later from Bow or Adora somehow. All her attention focused on the girl in front of her, who fiercely scribbled notes on the lesson. Maybe it was the many classes spent staring but Adora always seemed to be a constant, she always had a smile on her face and seemed to be absorbing all the information that was being dulled out to the class.

Today was different the same kind of different it felt had dragged on the past few weeks. Adora looked exhausted, she had been noticing small little changes in the girl. The bags under her eyes got deeper, she would zone out more and more during lunch and their conversations; that is if she didn't have her head buried in her books cramming facts and figures into her mind. The smile she grew to *lov...* like never quite reached her eyes anymore. Every time Bow and her made plans with Adora at the last minute something would happen and she had to cancel.

At first, each time she would ask Adora if everything was okay, Adora would shoot her a smile and say:

"Everything's fine!" and she would hold the smile just long enough to seem convincing before dropping it, the weight dragging on the corner of her lips.

But every time those words came out of her mouth, it seemed the facade she was desperate to hold up cracked just a bit more. Glimmer decided that she was going to get to the bottom of it because she couldn't bear to see her friend so wound up.

She pulled out her phone and sent a quick and sneaky text to Adora:

> **G**: Bow's leaving for camping today with the dads, so you and me girls night tonight & I will not be taking no for an answer. >:(

She looked up and saw Adora secretly check her phone to respond, she saw a small frown creep across her face as she typed her message:

> **A**: Idk Glim, I've got a lot of studying to do :(
>
> **G**: come on adora, we've been studying all week. please? how can you say no to this face

Glimmer saw Adora glance back and began to make a pleading face which brought a small smile to her:

> **A**: Okay, okay you win. I'm powerless against that face, rude
>
> **G**: :) <3

As soon as class ended, Glimmer bolted out of her seat; she knew she had a limited time frame to catch Adora before she and Bow ran off to soccer practice. Luckily, their lockers were near each other so she just waited near Adora's until the girl strolled out of class with Bow.

"You know most people try to leave Gen's class the moment the bell rings" Glimmer teased the two as she leaned against the lockers. Adora chuckled as she opened her locker to stuff textbooks into her bag.

"She's not *that bad,"* Bow defended their teacher

“She’s pretty bad” Adora retorted, making Glimmer laugh, she continued, “What time should I come over?”

“I leave for one weekend and you guys have a hangout with me. The betrayal,” Bow exaggerated as Glimmer gave him a light punch to the arm, not that it would do much to the muscular boy.

“After soccer? You can shower at my place, I still have your PJs from last time”

“Sounds good,” Adora replied. Glimmer noticed a slight blush kiss her face as she mentioned the PJs, probably nothing she thought.

“We’re gonna be late, Adora, and I *really* don’t want to do extra laps,” Bow said as he dragged the blonde away. The duo bid their farewells to Glimmer and she stood still for a moment watching them walk away from her, stuck in thought.

Glimmer had prepared everything for an epic night of relaxation she knew her friend desperately needed. The thought crossed her mind maybe she needed this too, lately her feelings for Adora had seemed to be shifting—not too sure where they were shifting but she knew how deeply she cared for her but not exactly in the same way she cared for Bow. It was different, *new,* and a little terrifying.

She pushed it down, tonight was about making sure Adora felt good and she didn’t need to know what exactly was going on but she just wanted to make sure she was okay.

It was approaching seven o’clock and the sun was starting to set when she heard a familiar car sound pull up into her drive away. Adora and Bow’s dad George had been fixing up an old car for the past few months and it was finally drivable but it had this one specific grinding sound when it was put in park that they just couldn’t figure out how to stop. But that didn’t stop Adora from jumping to drive the clunker around. Glimmer knew she didn’t

care because it was one thing she had, that was all hers, that her foster mother couldn't take possession of.

Glimmer jumped from the couch to the front door, she was about to open it to greet her friend when she heard Adora's phone ring through the door. She could immediately pick up the frustrated tone of the girl as she answered on the other side of the door. She didn't want to snoop but she couldn't help herself once she heard Adora's rising tone and hearing her say her foster mother's name. She pressed her ear to the door and could vaguely make out Adora's half of the conversation:

"Why do you care?.....I already did all my chores for the weekend yesterday because you wanted everything done before your boyfriend came over….I—I—I don't have a tone….I already texted you I'm spending the night at Glimmer's...She is not a bad influence! She's my friend!.....Can I get a word i—Yes ma'am. No ma'am….Yes...ma'am..."

Her heart hurt hearing her friend sound so defeated, she had never met Adora's foster mom and frankly she didn't want to. Adora didn't really speak about her at first when they all became friends but from the little things she did let slip, Glimmer and Bow could piece together enough to know she wasn't a good person. And again and again throughout the time they had been friends, Sharon had never failed to prove them right. Glimmer hated hearing about all the emotional manipulation Adora had gone through as a child and even now. Every time Adora would open up, the way she spoke so casually about her trauma tore Glimmer's heart apart.

Glimmer could hear Adora walk to the door and heard her exhale a shaky breath before softly knocking. The short girl took a second to compose herself, trying to shake the sadness and anger the conversation she overheard brought to her. She didn't want to add on to Adora's stress with her worry, so she took a deep breath and brought a cheerful smile to her face. She opened the door:

“Hey Glim” Adora smiled at her, absolutely filthy from soccer practice. Glimmer lunged at her wrapping her in a hug as she stood on her tiptoes.

“You made it! And wow you are stinky”

“Coach H made us do extra drills today” Adora wrapped her hands around her Glimmer hugging her back.

The stink of three hours of soccer drills invaded Glimmer’s senses but neither of them seemed ready to let go of each other. Once they parted, Glimmer dragged Adora into the house and ordered her to go take a shower while she got the snacks for their movie night ready.

Adora had spent a long time in the shower by the time she strolled out the sun had completely disappeared from the sky. Glimmer was already snug in her pajamas, working on a bowl of popcorn as she sat on the couch waiting for Adora. Glimmer patted the seat next to her, as the tall girl appeared in the living room, hair down and dripping wet outfitted in loose clothes that hid her form but still made the shorter girl’s stomach do cartwheels. She gulped as a bead of water fell down Adora’s brow as she made her way to the spot next to her their shoulder brushing as she did. She scooped up a handful of popcorn and asked:

“So, what are we watching tonight?”

“Your choice, whatever you want”

“Uhhh…” Adora began to think her thought interrupted as her phone began ringing. Glimmer could see the caller ID displayed, “Sharon Wheeler”, and a wave of small anger rose in her. “You pick the movie, I'll be right back” she rushed out.

Adora quickly jumped up and hurriedly answered the phone, she headed to the patio to take the call. This time Glimmer couldn’t make out any part of the conversation without Adora knowing she was blatantly listening in. But she could see the girl through the

glass window and her body language spoke louder than anything else. Even through a phone call, her foster mother could reduce the usually confident girl to a visage of a small child after a particularly harsh reprimand.

Adora walked back into the room, shoulder slightly hung. Glimmer tried to make light, even though she knew whatever conversation happened swallowed Adora whole.

"Robinhood: Men in Tights? You know, always a classic," Glimmer offered.

"Huh.." Adora sunk into the couch once more, this time a little further away from Glimmer, "Yeah, Glim sure whatever you want,"

"You okay, 'Dora?" Adora smiled, a half-life of the smile that usually warmed Glimmer's heart, her eyes faltering for just a slight moment with the truth.

"Everything's fine,"

Glimmer sighed, a little deeper and louder than she intended catching herself off guard hoping that Adora didn't notice. She pressed play and the movie began the surround sound filling the home. She glanced at Adora through her peripheral for a quick moment and she knew that Adora had noticed, as her face now twisted with a pang of unspoken and unwarranted guilt.

The movie didn't seem as funny as it usually did. Neither Glimmer nor Adora had laughed at the usual bits they would normally cry-laughing over or quoted the lines they had memorized twenty sleepovers ago. Glimmer would steal the occasional glances at her friend; most of the time she looked out of it, her mind someplace else where Glimmer couldn't reach though she desperately wanted to. The other times, the girl was fidgeting, never quite comfortable—her leg incessantly bouncing, playing with the hair tie around her wrist and her breathing seemed rapid at times and nonexistent at other times.

Once the credits began to roll, they made their way to Glimmer's room. Angella had come home from work at the point and greeted the girls. Glimmer saw Adora once again slip on a flimsy mask to chat with her mom. One Angella saw through immediately, pulling Glimmer aside as concern washed over her.

"She's fine mom, we're just tired! School was a pain today," Glimmer told her mother, not sure if her mother believed her or not but glad she didn't push it further.

When the two girls reached Glimmer's room the air between them was fragile. Adora once again looked at her phone and seemed so distant. They assumed their normal sleeping positions in Glimmer's bed, a bed they shared many sleepovers before but tonight a canyon seemed to separate them.

Glimmer couldn't tell if a minute had passed or several hours had, but it was clear neither of them were able to sleep. Adora constantly shifted trying to find a comfortable position and Glimmer laid on her back staring up at the ceiling, occasionally stealing glances. She heard Adora move on to her side, feeling the weight of her eyes staring at her. A shaky sigh escaped and the smallest whisper of her name followed:

"Glimmer…"

"Yeah, 'Dora?" Glimmer responded, matching Adora's tone. She turned her head hoping to see the girl, the light from the moon piercing the room offering a dim light source and only highlighting Adora's silhouette.

"Are you mad at me?"

The question caught Glimmer off guard and she could have sworn she saw the girl opposite of her bracing for impact, shrinking herself in.

"What? No, I'm not mad at you! Why would you think I was mad?"

“I know you were excited for tonight and the movie and I just feel like I ruined it,”

“You didn’t ruin anything…” Glimmer paused for a moment, taking a moment to collect her thoughts, not wanting to push Adora any further away, “ *Adora* , tonight wasn’t for me. I wanted it for you...I guess..” she sighed softly finally allowing her true feelings to show; “I’m just *worried* about you,”

She itched to reach out, to offer a gentle touch to the figure in the dim light. Maybe her fear stopped her but if it hadn’t the shudder of Adora’s body did. She heard three quick gasps struggling to breathe.

“Adora?”

She didn’t reply. Glimmer heard another set of three rapid inhales. Before Glimmer even turned on the lights to the room she knew. The moment the light filled the room Adora bolted upright gasping, eyes filled with tears, and her entire body shaking.

Glimmer rushed over to her side of the bed and threw the blanket still partly covering the blonde off, she laid her hands on Adora’s shoulder gently:

“Hey, hey look at me. Adora, look at me” Adora shook her head, “It’s okay, you’re okay, I’m right here”

Adora slowly shifted her head towards Glimmer who kept her eye contact and imitated deep slow breaths for her to follow.

“Four things you can touch, you can do it” Glimmer made her voice as low and slow as possible, moving her hands from the girl’s shoulders, trying to hide her own worry knowing it wouldn’t help Adora to sense it.

“B-bed,” Adora squeezed the mattress below her, “P-p-pillow” her fingers grazed the pillow her head previously laid on, “K-Kowl” she reached over to Glimmer’s tattered childhood stuffed owl.

“Good, you’re doing so great, one more” Glimmer reassured. Adora reached out to grab her arm and let out a shaky breath continuing:

“You, Glimmer”

“Perfect, okay, Now three things you hear, anything” Glimmer placed her hand over Adora’s still tight around her forearm.

“The...the ceiling fan...the dog that...that..” Adora’s labored breathing started to pick up again, Glimmer squeezed her hand stroking her thumb over the back of Adora’s palm.

“Take your time, you’re doing amazing”

“Dog keeps barking...and I hear your voice”

“Good, okay. Two things you smell”

“Angella’s takeout” Adora let out a small breathy chuckle causing Glimmer to smile wide, “And your lavender shampoo—in my hair” Adora let out a deep exhale.

“Last one, one thing you can taste”

“Your mom’s weird natural toothpaste” The blonde let out a bigger laugh and Glimmer joined her. Adora’s breathing finally evened out, no longer quick and shallow, now thoughtfully and purposefully deep and long Their gazes met again and Adora’s laugh held on for a moment before a shuddering breath left her and she crumbled. Glimmer moved to sit next to her on the bed, pulling her into her side letting her fall apart in this moment.

They sat for a while, Glimmer only moving to go get water for Adora. Now they sat in the middle of the bed backs pressed up against the wall neither sure how to start. Adora was the first to speak, her voice a whisper:

“Thanks..”

“No need, you’re my best friend,” Glimmer said, pausing though her next question lingered in the air, “Adora, what’s going on?”

Adora sighed, dragging her hands down her face, she pulled her knees into her chest. Glimmer’s heart hurt seeing her make herself so small.

“It’s just been...a lot. School, college, soccer. This is it…” she paused. “What if...what if Sharon’s right? That my grades aren’t good enough for Brightmoon University...that *I’m* not good enough? That you and Bow will get it and I won’t? And I’ll be stuck there with her? What would I even study or do with my life? Maybe I shouldn’t eve—”

“She’s wrong” Glimmer cut Adora off, her voice stoic and firm. She turned to Adora, her attempt at hiding her scowl at hearing about Sharon failing, “Adora, you’re an amazing student. You pay attention, you do the work, and even when you don’t get something right way *you don’t give up* ”

Adora turned to look at Glimmer as she continued:

“Not only, but you’re also fucking amazing on that field. Watching you play...? Adora even if you didn’t get into BU based on grades, which wouldn’t happen because again: you’re so smart. I’m pretty sure they’re dying to have...what did the newspaper call you again?”

“Oh God..” a blush danced its way across Adora’s cheeks

“ *Oh yeah...* Brightmoon’s Sensational Bad Ass Soccer Star”

“I’m pretty sure they didn’t put ‘Bad Ass’ in the newspaper”

“Well they should have because I know what I’m talking about” The girls shared a short chuckle before Glimmer continued, her voice shifting back into a firm, but soft voice. “I don’t think a lot of us have any of it figured it out yet, you know, what we want to do.”

“Bow does,” Adora interjected, raising her head up.

“Bow is an outlier...and should not be counted. I don’t know what I want to do yet, and that’s okay. We’ll figure it out like, we always do. All of us, when we all get to BU because I know we will.”

She softly jabbed Adora’s side, trying to raise a smile out of her.

“You are more than enough despite what *Sharon* fucking thinks. And...I know opening up isn’t the easiest for you and I get it,” Glimmer placed a comforting hand on Adora’s knee, “But you don’t have to deal with this all alone. You’ve got Bow and *you’ve got me.* Trust that we have your back. Let yourself have dreams, Adora, you’re going to get everything you want in life.”

Glimmer saw Adora smile, a smile she hadn’t seen in weeks, and felt the tension ease her mind for a moment.

They spent the next two hours talking, Adora doing her best to allow Glimmer to share in her burden. Which caused both of them to realize just how much the future weighed on them. Their own distinct pressures and expectations from themselves but also everyone around them and the fear of failure that plagued them both.

Glimmer watched the sleeping girl next to her as much as she had wanted to help Adora tonight they ended up helping each other. Being open and honest with each other with things neither thought the other could understand. She counted the seconds of the blonde’s inhales and exhales, willing them to stay consistent to allow her friend a good night's rest.

Glimmer’s eyes outlined the curves of the face deep in slumber and the same subtle indescribable feeling in the pit of her stomach came roaring back. It had been a constant for months now and Glimmer still couldn’t quite place a name to it. Her mind ran through her entire vocabulary trying to find the perfect words to name it. A small rustle of the bed broke her concentration.

Adora’s face scrunched and twisted seemingly in pain briefly; her were eyes still shut and her mind deep in a dream. She whimpered out a single word:

“Glimmer..?” It was a quiet plea. Glimmer didn’t remember loving her name as much as she did than the first moment she heard how it sounded coming out of Adora’s mouth. She brushed back a fallen hair from her face and whispered:

“Right here, Adora”

Adora’s body once again settled, calming instantly at the sound of her voice, scooting in towards Glimmer. A lightning strike cracked inside of Glimmer as she watched her friend nestle in closer to her.

“ *Oh,* that’s what it is, ” Glimmer thought to herself chuckling. Finally letting herself join Adora is some much-needed sleep.

'falling in love, just you and me'

“Who thought it was a good idea to schedule prom on the same day BU sends out their decisions!” Glimmer groaned, “I bet it was Catra seems like something she would do”

Adora hid a snicker as she watched the pink-haired girl easily apply her makeup flawlessly next to Perfuma.

“Glimmer, I’m literally the student body president, why are you blaming Catra, she barely shows up to the meetings!” Bow responded as he steamed two suit blazers

“But wasn’t she the one to suggest tod—” Perfuma interjected before Bow loudly cleared his throat shaking his head to stop his girlfriend from offering further context. Both Adora and Bow could see the glare Glimmer shot Bow in her mirror.

She let out a laugh before Glimmer’s glare turned on her, although this time it was more playful to which Adora threw her hands up in defeat. She laid back down on Glimmer's bed as Bow resumed steaming their suit blazers. She aimlessly refreshed her email, anxiety filling her stomach.

She thought to herself, maybe Glimmer did have a point. Who schedules a prom the same day decision letters come out? Her mind filled with all the what-ifs: what if she didn’t get it into BU? What if she had to go to a school far away from her friends and her support system? What if she doesn’t get into any program and is stuck living with Sharon for the foreseeable future?

As if Glimmer had heard her inner monologue, Adore felt her phone being gently taken from her hand and a sweet voice saying:

“Hey, no panicking without us,” her eyes fell on a familiar smile that instantly calmed her mind, “Perfuma and I are going to get

our dresses on in my mom's room. Bow, if she even looks at her phone, tackle her or something"

"Don't worry Adora!" Perfuma reassured as she placed a small kiss on the shorter boy's cheek, "I'm sure we'll all get it! I can feel it!"

Adora always appreciated Perfuma's boundless optimistic outlook even when everyone could tell it was all she could do from freaking out herself. They were all stressed, even Bow who usually keeps a cool and calm air around him when it comes to school, seemed to be constantly peering over at his phone.

Bow reached out a hand and offered it to her to lift her off the bed, the two began to get dressed as the girls got ready in the other room. Adora opted for a loose tie for her suit and Bow, a bowtie. It hadn't taken too long for either of them to get ready and once they were done Adora danced over to where Glimmer had placed her phone but before she could even unlock it she heard Bow's voice as he bent over to pick up Glimmer's room.

"Adora, no, absolutely not."

"Come on Bow, just a peek I know you want to know too!" Adora leaped in front of Bow grabbing both of his arms, shaking him. Bow's face began to twist, his mind justifying giving in and checking along with Adora.

Glimmer's voice boomed as the bedroom door opened:

"Don't even think about it"

The pair turned around to find Glimmer and Perfuma entering the room. Silence overtook both Adora and Bow. Adora breathing halted as she saw Glimmer for the first time in her prom dress.

Next to her Bow, whispered a small, "Wow" as his eyes filled with tears he ran over to Perfuma and lifted her planting small kisses on both her cheeks.

The blonde felt a pang of jealousy as Glimmer moved next to her, everything in Adora wanted to mimic Bow and scoop up Glimmer into her arms planting purposeful kisses on her cheeks.

“What do you think?” Glimmer asked her voice the most vulnerable Adora had ever heard it get.

“You look absolutely breatht—” A quick four separate notifications filled the room and the group froze. “Glimmer…” Adora whispered anxiously.

They each walked slowly to their phones. Bow and Perfuma held hands while staring individually at their phones. Glimmer and Adora hovered close to each other. No one wanted to be the first to speak, Adora could hear Glimmer inhale a deep breath before she broke the silence:

“On three?” she asked, her voice quivering.

“On three.” they all responded. Adora being the last voice to join in the chorus a quiet hesitation settling onto her.

“One” Perfuma began

“Two” Bow continued

“Three” Glimmer ended the countdown and the succession of the unlocked phones and gasps being held. Adora hesitated as she held her phone in her hand, the email notification taunting her. Her thought spiral restarted tenfold only the squeal of Perfuma breaking through:

“I got in!” Perfuma threw her hands around Bow’s neck as he sighed heavily, the pressure being lifted off his back.

“Me too, I got in too!” Bow melted into his embrace with his girlfriend.

“Ah! I got in!” Glimmer’s voice filled the room. Adora stood there her heart simultaneously excited and happy for her friends but

dreading her own result. “Adora…?”

Adora felt three sets of eyes burning into her and any semblance of a defense she could muster was knocked out of the window the moment her friends had found out their fate.

“What if—” she swallowed, her voice shaking, “What if I don’t get in?” She felt Glimmer’s hand fall into hers and their fingers comfortably interlocking. Glimmer squeezed once.

“No matter what Adora, we’ve got your back. I know you’ll get it I can feel it,” Glimmer spoke in a voice that Adora often recognized on the many nights they would fall asleep on a video call. Bow moved to Adora’s side and placed a hand on her shoulder and shot her a smile.

She took a deep breath and clicked the email, her eyes quickly scanning the words.

Dear Adora Grayson….Congratulations!....Soccer Scholarship...Academic Scholarship...We look forward to hearing…

“I..I got in?” she spoke in disbelief, “ *I got in!* ” the realization setting in Adora could only feel her three friends squeezing her.

A chorus of congratulations sounded through the room before the group rushed down to the living room where Angella, George, and Lance had been waiting for them all, newfound excitement for the night overtaken each of them ready to share the news with their parents.

Adora grabbed a cup of bad prom punch from a cheerful Scropia and began to wander around the auditorium. The energy of the night was incredible and the group had been having a great night with their friends, even when Glimmer compelled Adora to dance with her.

Adora took a sip for her drink before her eyes fell on Bow who sat in a dim corner of the auditorium watching Glimmer and Perfuma

dance with each other. She made her way over to Bow pulling a seat next to him.

“What a night,” Adora spoke incredulously in a small chuckle.

“What a night. Doesn’t seem real?” Bow spoke, his voice tame causing Adora to grow concerned.

“Are you okay, Bow?”

“Yeah! I’m great! I..I just…” he paused. He let out a breathy chuckle before turning to Adora, “Do you remember the Brightmoon Honors College..Don’t tell Glimmer I wanna be the first one to tell her but...I got accepted”

Adora’s eyes grew wide and her smile nearly split her face.

“Holy shit! Bow!” the blonde pulled her best friend in for a tight embrace. Adora knew how much the program had meant to him and in the same thought she had a sudden realization, “Wait..wait I thought you decided to not apply? To just transfer in once you got into BU?”

The two broke their hug and Bow focused his eyesight on the two girls still dancing the night away.

“I know, I know”

“What made you change your mind? And why didn’t you tell us?”

“Honestly? Perfuma helped me change my mind” He eyes darted to his girlfriend and a large smile grew on his face, “After I decided not to apply we talked about it and she helped me see that I was scared? I don’t want this to sound cocky but I’m one of the top students I knew had a good chance of getting it but I was terrified”

“Oh Bow…”

"When I decided I wasn't gonna apply I just thought, sure on paper I was the ideal candidate but I felt like I wasn't going to be good enough and I didn't want to take the chance that I would be *told* I wasn't good enough for them."

"I get that, really, that fear? It's paralyzing. Just the 'what if' of it all," Adora leaned forward, her eyes flickering between a dancing Glimmer and her hands tightening around her drink. Bow shifted his glance to Adora and followed her eyesight to where he expected it to land. He chuckled to himself softly.

"You know Adora, I thought it would be enough to just get into BU and then gamble getting into the Honors program later because I was scared of not being enough and I convinced myself I just wasn't what they wanted." He took a moment to reflect on his words, "I think wanting it made me scared of losing it if I went for it. What if I'm not enough, what if I get turned down, what if *they don't want me.* But I realized I couldn't spend my life without at least trying."

Bow took a sip of this drink before continuing:

"The 'what if's are scary. I realized whether or not I got in, my not trying would stay with me for the rest of my time at BU and probably the rest of my life. The entirety of my life would be a big what if." Bow turned to look at Adora fully, her attention split between listening to him and watching a certain pink-haired girl. "I think it's important to do the things that scare us, to take the leaps that are absolutely terrifying. They might surprise you."

There was a moment of silence between the two before Bow started to speak again:

"Glimmer sure looks beautiful tonight, doesn't she?" he said as a smirk crept on his face.

"Yeah…" Adora's smile grew, "She sure does," a moment of clarity washed over Adora as she snapped and turned to Bow who sat

completely satisfied with himself. Adora stammered struggling to gather her words. "I—Um...I.."

Bow stood up dusted himself and shot Adora a wink:

"I'm gonna go dance with my girlfriend. Think about what I said: don't let the what-ifs scare you, you'd be surprised"

Adora sat in disbelief, *"Does Bow know?"* Before Adora could even process Bow's words to her she sees an exhausted Glimmer headed to her.

"Hey you," Glimmer smiled

"Want to sit with me for a minute?" Adora pulled a chair closer to her side for Glimmer.

"Yeah, I'm kinda all danced out"

Glimmer nestled into Adora's side and the loud music of the auditorium began to muffle as Adora's beating heart took over her eardrums. Bow's words accompanied the beating playing in perfect rhythm to her pounding heart.

Her eyes fixated on Bow and Perfuma slow dancing the lights seemed to dance off of their bodies as they twirled and laughed softly to each other. She felt a big gulp go down her throat as Glimmer inched closer and held on tighter to her arm. Adora let out a slow steady breath as her eyes flickered to the ceiling not daring to look to the shorter girl next to her as she struggled to speak but before she could she heard Glimmer speak:

"I'm so excited we're all going to the same school, I can't imagine not being able to see you every day" her voice was soft, the tiniest bit raspy from singing along to the music all night.

"Glim.." she whispered ever so softly, scared to disturb this small moment between them.

“Hmm…” Glimmer hummed, Adora could practically feel the vibrations throughout her body, “What’s up ‘Dora?”

The blonde hesitated, Glimmer was the first person to ever give her the nickname and it easily became her favorite. It caught on amongst their friends quickly but only in Glimmer’s mouth did it send shivers and warmth to every bit of Adora’s body.

“You look beautiful tonight,” Adora paused and quickly began to stammer, “ Not that you don’t always look beautiful! You always look great! I just—just mean..um—” Adora’s fast verbal mesh of words came to a stop as she heard Glimmer’s infectious laugh and the pink-haired girl’s body weight shift off of her side.

“I know what you mean…” Glimmer said through her chuckles and even through the dim light gym Adora could swear she saw a blush streak her face as Glimmer pushed back a strand of loose hair behind her ear before she continued, “You look great tonight too, very *beautiful* meets *handsome* ”

Now it was Adora’s turn for a blush to appear on her face.

“T-Thanks Glim”

Glimmer laid her body back into Adora’s side this time sliding her hand into Adora’s interlocking their fingers, a common and usually innocent act between the two girls. This time felt different, the air surrounding the two seemingly changing instantly. It was different, new but familiar and comfortable; it was Glimmer of course it would be Adora thought.

Adora had always dreaded the thought of her graduation day. A day for most of her classmates and friends meant family cheering for you in the stands as you walked across a stage, praying you don’t fall, and finally being done with the hellscape that is the high school experience. The thought of hearing her name being called and knowing that she wouldn’t have any family to cheer her on was the source of so many nightmares throughout her life.

Never in her wildest dreams could she have imagined how the day would turn out.

As she heard her name booming on the loudspeaker she heard the cheers of the family she had made for herself.

"Go, Adora!" She heard Bow scream

She could hear the whoops and hollers from George and Lance and all twelve of Bow's brothers that were just as loud as when Bow had walked just moments earlier. George and Lance always treated her like family helping her when they could. They had so much love to share and even after sharing that with thirteen children of their own they found it in their hearts to extend that to her.

She knew Angella would never be the one to yell but the presence of one of the most powerful woman she knew standing and clapping for her brought her such a sense of warmth especially considering she could hear the loudest person in the huddle of people, Angella's daughter—her *girlfriend* , Glimmer.

Since prom night the energy around them had been intimate and delicate and neither knew what to say to broach the subject but one late night they knew. And the rest had just fallen into place. The two girls fit together perfectly, they always had except now they were able to share their true feelings for each other.

They had spent the entire night catching each other up: when they each knew why they never said anything, and how happy they were that even though it might have taken a little bit longer to find each other they both wouldn't change anything.

And now it was graduation, a day they both had been absolutely excited for and terribly dreading. Adora, as an official part of the Brightmoon University Moonstone Soccer Team, had to leave the day of graduation to start training camp.

"If you need anything don't hesitate to give us a call" Lance was holding both of Adora's hands in his as Bow loaded the last piece

of luggage into her car. She had been staying with them for a little over two months now. She didn't come with much but even in the short time with them left with more than she ever could have imagined.

George's head was under the hood of Adora's car tinkering away to both run one last check on the former clunker now functioning vehicle and to slightly spare himself the sadness of saying goodbye. Bow nudged his father and his head shot up from the car engine:

"God, she runs like a beauty now! And she's not making that sound anymore!" George proudly said as she slammed the car hood shut.

"I told you it was the radiator belt" Lance slyly said as he snuck up behind his husband.

"Hey, look who it is" Bow placed a hand on Adora's shoulder as Angella and Glimmer walked up the driveway, "I guess it's officially time for goodbyes" he choked back a sob.

One by one they all embraced Adora.

George and Lance enveloped the blonde in a tight hug, whispering small affirmations to her. Angella pulled Adora into a tight hug, the woman towered over her but as she had gotten to know her knew how much love and care she had in her heart.

The parents wandered away as the trio prepared to say their own goodbyes. They would all be meeting up again in the fall but the realization that this would be the first summer they've spent apart since becoming the best friend squad was more overwhelming than any of them could imagine.

The trio all embraced in a tight hug soon after they broke off, Bow and Adora shared their own goodbye:

"You're gonna kick ass at camp, show them what you're made of" Bow's eyes filled with tears.

“I wish my number two was gonna be with me,” Adora lightly jabbed him in this shoulder

“I’m your best friend Adora, I’m always with you”

The two entered another embrace this time tighter than before letting go and Bow heading inside to allow his two best friends to have a moment.

Adora reaches out for Glimmer’s hands and leads her next to her car, she leans against the car door and pulls the shorter girl into a gentle hold.

“Three months, we sure picked a great time to start dating huh?” Glimmer spoke as she clutched Adora’s shirt

“We did always have perfect timing,” they both shared a small laugh before growing quiet again, simply taking in each other's presence for as long as they can, “But yeah we have a plan, we’ll message when we can and video chat like we always do”

“I’m gonna miss you so much”

“Me too,” Adora took a small pause, “Glimmer, thank you for reminding me to dream. You were right: I got everything I ever want right here in my arms”

Glimmer pushed off slightly from Adora’s chest and placed a gentle hand on her cheek before she placed a sweet kiss on the other,

“You’re such a dork,”

“You love it,” Adora pushed a stray hair from Glimmer’s face

“I sure do”

They stayed in their embrace for what did not seem long enough and soon enough Adora was in the driver seat ready to head on a new adventure. She backed out of the driveway and couldn’t help

but watch Glimmer make silly faces to keep herself from tearing up.

“I’ve got my location shared but I’ll message you when I get there?” Adora shouted her voice cracking rather unexpectedly.

“Sound perfect,” shouted back waving as she watched the car drive away.

Adora placed both hands on the steering wheel, let out a big sigh and turned on a playlist she and Glimmer had made for the trip, she allowed a few tears to drop. She couldn’t help to think about Glimmer and their future. They had only been together a few weeks but from the moment Adora realized how much she cared for her, she knew. This was her dream.

End Notes

Check out all my friends' pages and devour their content! It's all amazing!

Athetos
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Curiousscientistkae
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